Best Laid Plans

Your job is to predict, *before you start*, the week the customer will accept your work. Then run the project and find out how right you were.

Step 1
Open and read
Open the link, enter the code on the board, and read The Contract tab. Every tab is open from the start.

Step 2
Plan, then commit
Choose a plan, check whatever you think you need on the desk, then commit three numbers.

Step 3
Run the line
One decision round per week until the customer accepts, or the contract is cancelled.

Step 4
Stop and sketch
At "finished," don't reveal. Sketch your answer and wait. Then download your results.

THE CONTRACT



200 units · 4 crews to start · $5.00M budget + $0.5M credit (past it: bankrupt) · each crew costs $50k a week

BEFORE WEEK 1: YOUR PLAN, THEN THREE NUMBERS

Your plan: crews to add at the start (none, +1, +2, +3); inspection (0, 10, 20 or 30%); second shift (none, late weeks, every week). You can change course later.

The desk: The Contract · Status Report · Project Controls (burn-down, defect control chart) · What-if Planner · Team Chat (five approaches) · Ask an AI · Last 5 Contracts · Records (40 past contracts, downloadable as a CSV) · Risk Register (yours). They disagree; deciding which to trust is the exercise.

① The week
The week you think the customer accepts all 200 units.

② An 80% range
Earliest to latest week, so that you'd bet **4 to 1** the outcome lands inside it.

③ Chance of week 12
Your honest probability, 0–100%, that it's accepted by the deadline.

EACH WEEK YOU MAY

MOVE	EFFECT	COST
Add crews (up to 3)	More capacity, but the whole line runs at 70% for 2 weeks while they learn. Beyond 4 crews, every crew gets a bit less efficient.	$100k each
Release a crew	Lower weekly cost	$50k
Second shift	+30% output. From the second straight week, tired crews make more defects.	$20k / crew
Inspect 0–30%	Moves capacity from building to checking. Finds defects while they're cheap.	capacity
Move your forecast	Update your estimate. Only your week-1 commitment is scored. After key events, tap Keep or Change.	free

HOW YOU'RE SCORED

Forecast: the score that counts most. It measures how right you were about your own project.

Start	100
For each week your point forecast was off	−8
Your 80% range: for each week of its width	−3
...and for each week the outcome fell outside it	−30
Chance-of-week-12 error: 40 × (your % − what happened)²	up to −40

Never delivered (bankrupt or cancelled): Forecast 0. **Delivery**: 100, minus 12 per week late and 1 per $50k over budget. Zero if never delivered.

Two separate scores. You can deliver late and still forecast well.

WHAT AN 80% RANGE MEANS

If you made ten forecasts like this one, about **eight** should land inside your range and about **two** outside. A range that never misses is too wide; one that usually misses is too narrow.

HONEST BEATS BOLD

Say 80% and it happens: you lose `0.04 × 40 ≈ 2`. Say 80% and it doesn't: you lose `0.64 × 40 ≈ 26`. Say what you actually believe.

ROOM RULES

- Play alone. No talking about numbers until the reveal.
- Use the code on the board.
- Only your **first** play counts. Download its results file (run 1) before you replay.
- At the end, keep your results screen open: your instructor will ask for a show of hands.

THE SKETCH (ON PAPER, BEFORE YOU REVEAL)

The week you think it was accepted: _____ Did your 80% range hold? Yes / No How sure are you? ____ / 100
What did you mostly look at when you committed? _____
What was your plan, and why? _____

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AFTER THE REVEAL

Every forecast is seen through a frame that can see some things and is blind to others.

FRAMES YOU COULD HAVE USED TONIGHT

The pace
Extrapolate the current rate. **Sees** output so far. **Blind to** defects and scope changes. The trap: anchoring.

The plan
Run the movie step by step. **Sees** your choices. **Blind to** everything outside the plan. A plan is a chain: ten 90% steps ≈ 35%.

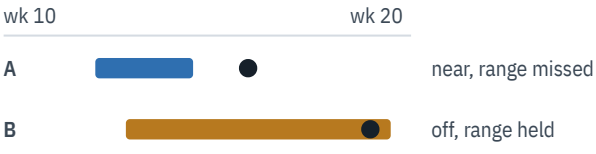
The dashboard
"Percent complete." **Sees** what was built. **Blind to** what will pass. The 90% syndrome.

One vivid case
"Last time it took..." **Sees** one real outcome. **Blind to** whether you'll play like it.

The record
What happened to things like this. **Sees** what the plan forgot. **Blind to** plans no one has tried, and to true novelty.

Models, crowds, AI
Regression, simulation, colleagues, chatbots. **Only as good as** what they're fed, and averaging helps only if they err differently.

CALIBRATION IS NOT ACCURACY



Bar = 80% range · dot = what happened

Hire forecaster B. Judge forecasters on many forecasts, never on one outcome.

WHAT A 90% FORECAST MEANS

In 2016 forecasters gave Clinton roughly 85–90%. She lost. That alone doesn't make them wrong. A 10–15% event happens one time in seven to ten. The question is never "did the 90% happen?" It's "of all the 90% calls, how many came true?"

THE FOUR MOVES: FOR ANY DATE YOU'LL BE HELD TO

1 · Record
What happened to things like this? Find 5–40 comparable cases. Pick the class before you look at its answer.

2 · Difference
What makes this one different, and is that evidence or hope? Intentions don't count.

3 · Range
Would you bet 4 to 1? Then widen it for what your frame can't see. Try a premortem: "It failed. Why?"

4 · Score
Write it down with a date. Update in small steps. Check how your 80% calls actually did.

READING YOUR RESULTS SCREEN

- **Your game in 9 facts.** Numbered for a show of hands: your plan, your starting point, what you checked (how often, whether you stopped, and your AI use), the 90% week and the rejections, the scope change, whose numbers you used, whether your range held, money, and luck (your decisions replayed under 100 other draws).
- **Your risk register.** Which of your risks happened, and which happened that you didn't list.
- **The lesson line.** "Your dashboard said week X. The past contracts said week Y. It was accepted in week Z."
- **Forecast and Delivery scores.** Each with the points every part cost, as on the front.
- **How each tool on the desk would have done,** with what each could and couldn't see.
- **"What your dashboard told you."** The gap between 100% on the dashboard and acceptance is the rework it couldn't see.
- **Download my results (.txt).** Keep it for the discussion; a replay saves as a new run.

TAKE IT WITH YOU

What's one date you've already promised someone this month?

Which frame produced it? _____

What does the record of things like it say? _____

Next week: judge the decision, not the outcome.

Readings: Knight 1921 · Tversky & Kahneman 1974 · Petropoulos et al. 2022 · Mellers et al. 2015 · Schoemaker 1995 · Taleb 2007